BLAST OR BUST

MODULE 2: OBSTACLE GENERATION



When the Referee needs an immediate challenge for the party, roll **one die of each polyhedral tier** (1d4, 1d6, 1d8, 1d10, 1d12, and 1d20) in a single throw. In seconds, this generates the obstacle's Difficulty Threshold, evocative form, required Attributes, retaliatory Counterattack, and Health Pool.

POLYHEDRAL MATRIX: CORE ANATOMY

▲ 1d4	Threshold	Difficulty Tier
1	**14+**	Moderate Obstacle
2	**17+**	Hard Obstacle
3	**20+**	Extreme / Legendary
4	***Reroll***	Escalated Flux (Roll again)

◆ 1d6	Descriptor
1	**Ancient**
2	**Mechanical**
3	**Magical**
4	**Shiny**
5	**Dusted**
6	**Odd**

◆ 1d8	Obstacle Form
1	**Animal**
2	**Guardian**
3	**Storm**
4	**Trap**
5	**Door**
6	**Gang**
7	**Person**
8	**Feeling**

OBSTACLE HEALTH POOL (1D20)

FORMULA: 10 + 1D20

Roll **1d20** and add **10** to establish current Obstacle HP (**Range: 11 to 30 HP**). Physical obstacles track Physical HP damage; environmental and psychic impasses deplete the pool through Mental actions.

INSTANT ROLL EXAMPLE

Dice Roll: 1d4 [2: 17+] • 1d6 [5: Dusted] • 1d8 [2: Guardian] • 1d10 [7: COS + WIT] • 1d12 [8: Disarm] • 1d20 [14: 24 HP].
Narrative Translation: A *Dusted Guardian* (ancient stone colossus half-buried in the white dunes). Hard Threshold **17+** with **24 HP**. To defeat it, characters must endure its toxic choking plumes (**COS**) or outmaneuver its blind swings (**WIT**). If it survives the turn (or a character Busts), its pneumatic sweep knocks their weapon away!

ENGAGEMENT & COMPLICATIONS

ATTRIBUTES TO FIGHT IT (1D10)

DUAL COMBAT TESTING

In Blast or Bust, every obstacle engages body and spirit. Players may roll either assigned Attribute:

[1] Strength + Wits (STR / WIT)
[2] Strength + Knowledge (STR / KNO)
[3] Strength + Presence (STR / PRE)
[4] Agility + Wits (AGI / WIT)
[5] Agility + Knowledge (AGI / KNO)
[6] Agility + Presence (AGI / PRE)
[7] Constitution + Wits (COS / WIT)
[8] Constitution + Knowledge (COS / KNO)
[9] Constitution + Presence (COS / PRE)
[10] *Reroll (Wild Fluctuations)*

THE COMPLICATION & COUNTERATTACK MATRIX (1D12)

*When the obstacle **survives a turn with HP > 0** (or when a character **Busts**), it inflicts this lethal reaction:*

1d12	Retaliatory Effect / Hazardous Consequence
1	**Accumulated Trauma:** Deals **1d4 damage** for each time the character was already damaged by this obstacle.
2	**Gear Shatter:** Deals 0 damage, but completely destroys an item of the character's choice.
3	**Violent Tumble:** Knocks the character prone (must spend an action or roll AGI to stand).
4	**Psychic Terror:** Inflicts **1d10 Mental Damage (MP)** directly to composure.
5	**Pressure Relief:** Step down the Tension Die by one tier (e.g., d8 → d6).
6	**Vampiric Drain:** Inflicts **1d6 damage** and the obstacle heals that same amount of HP.
7	**Overwhelming Dread:** All characters' difficulty thresholds rise by one step for the scene.
8	**Weapon Snatch:** Knocks a weapon or special item from grasp, requiring an action to retrieve.
9	**Ash Blinding:** Character is blinded for **1d4 rounds** (all checks suffer disadvantage).
10	**Mental Lock:** Forces all opponents to use exclusively Mental attacks on their next turn.
11	**Mitosis:** The obstacle instantly duplicates itself (sharing identical current HP).
12	**Miraculous Whiff:** Nothing happens; the blow strikes empty sand.

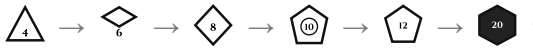
THE ESCALATION ENGINE

Tension is physical. It sits in the center of the table, creeping ever closer to cataclysm with every broken gamble.

THE TENSION DIE RULE — CENTRAL TABLE CLOCK

When introducing this module, the Referee places a **d4** at the center of the table designated as the **Tension Die**.

- **Escalation on Bust:** Each time a player **Busts** (exceeds 21 on a sequential push-your-luck chain), **step up the Tension Die by one tier**:

CALM (D4)  CATACLYSM (D20)

- **Climax & Reset:** At the **conclusion of each scene**, the Referee rolls the accumulated Tension Die, consults the **Wasteland Threat Table** below, resolves the threat, and **resets the Tension Die back to d4**.
- **Lowering the Die:** Players can lower the Tension Die by one step by impressing the narrator with **stunning roleplay** or profound narrative sacrifice (at the Referee's sole discretion).

Roll	Threat Level	Threat Encounter (Sample Manifestations)	Referee Narrative Directive & Stakes
1–5	SAFE	Safe haven, abandoned cistern, minor tactical advantage, or vital ancient intel.	Allows the story to move forward; players catch their breath and consolidate plans.
6–7	MINOR	Corrosive sand-lice, rusted hinges, blinding squall, or terrain slowing element.	Spices up the wasteland march; requires party cooperation to devise a smart solution.
8–9	MODERATE	Active opposing obstacles: wasteland thugs, scavenger ambush, or a hungry pack of saur-jackals.	A genuine battle or challenge; excellent opportunity for characters to shine and gain milestone XP.
10–11	SEVERE	Life-threatening danger: colossal biomechanical terror, villain confrontation, or veteran bounty hunter band.	Do not underestimate. A character could be severely maimed, crippled, or lose a cherished relic.
12–19	EXTREME	Supernatural cataclysm: awakening avatar of a minor evil god, sworn Nemesis squad, inescapable run-away hazard.	Far above party level. Certain death for one or more characters unless the entire party runs for their lives!
20	EPIC	Violent tectonic earthquake, fire-tornado, localized orbital laser strike, or dust-tsunami.	Unescapable doom. Somebody must deliberately sacrifice their life so the rest have a chance to live.

AIDING OTHERS INSTEAD OF TAKING ACTIONS — HIGH STAKES COLLABORATION

During any conflict or obstacle phase, players may choose to **declare support and help an ally's action** rather than acting independently. The active player gains **one Tactical Bonus for each aiding ally**.

The Cascading Failure Warning: If the obstacle **survives the turn (or the active player Busts), all helping players also suffer the obstacle's full Counterattack**! Furthermore, on a **Bust (> 21)**, the **Tension Die steps up by one tier for EVERY aiding player** (in addition to the tier increase from the active player's Bust).

1. BUST INSURANCE (REROLL ON BUST)

If the sequential roll exceeds 21, the active player may immediately discard the busting die and roll once more to stay in the game.

2. THRESHOLD REDUCTION

Lowers the target Obstacle Difficulty Threshold by one complete step for this attempt (e.g., **20**$^{+}$ → **17**$^{+}$, or **17**$^{+}$ → **14**$^{+}$).

3. DEVASTATING IMPACT (DAMAGE REROLL)

On a successful hit (Step 3: Damage Roll), the player may reroll all damage dice to maximize final damage dealt to the Obstacle's HP.

4. COMPETENCE SHIFT (BETTER DIE)

The active player may step up their rolling die by one competence tier for this check (e.g., upgrade **d20 → d12** or **d10 → d8**).